From the Mississippi Delta

By Endesha Ida Mae Holland

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): **(Pg 49-50)** Children who spend most of their time around grown-ups grow old and wise faster than children who seldom see grown-ups except at meals or when some teacher is talking at them. Children left to other children are only children, but children like me – with Mama always talking and telling me about life – are at one child and adult. One of her favorite topics was how proud I'd be of her once she got her permit to practice granny midwifery, a goal that always seemed somehow out of reach.

MAMA: You gots ta have a dream, 'f'n you gwine be somebody.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): In Mama's dream, she was dressed in a clean white starched dress just like nurses wore, and she was toting a bulging black bag like doctors carried. But the hospital wouldn't treat colored women, so Mama would help until Dr. Feinberg and the granny midwife got there. Mama had magic hands. Once they arrived much later than the baby who'd arrived [only] with Mama's help. Dr. Feinberg said . .

DR. FEINBERG: You ought to become a granny catcher your own self.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): That's when it started, Mama's dream of catching babies.

INTRODUCTION

For a young Black girl growing up in Mississippi in the turbulent 1960's life held promises of poverty, prejudice, and broken dreams. Ida Mae Holland refused to accept such a bitter legacy, and with her mother's inspiration, reinvented herself from meager beginnings. But as a young Civil Rights activist, she encounters the greatest test of her spirit and perseverance – the fire-bombing of her home with her mother inside.

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NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): **(Pg 50-51)** Now to lots of folks any dream of bettering yourself was an uppity kind of dream. Too many of them had dreamed of a better life, even worked at it, without success. And rather than be tortured by dreams, many decided not to dream at all. **So** Mama was brave, in dreaming – in wanting something despite the odds. And the odds were

long. A licensed granny midwife had to be able to read and write . . . Mama didn't know her ABC's! [But] This was Mama's grand dream, the dream from which I learned how to dream--big and unafraid, no matter what obstacles or bitterness are put in your way.

MAMA: You gotta start somewhere, an' a dream is jest as good a place as any!

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): Mama had another dream -- that I would go to college. She was proud that I could read and write and she understood the importance of education. Although it was too late for her, it wasn't for me.

IDA MAE: **(Pg 52-53)** I gots me a dream, too.

MAMA: What for! Dreamt 'bout pee-de-bed?

IDA MAE: No, Mama. I's talkin' bout a dream like yours.

MAMA: I beg your pardon, chile -- what you mean?

IDA MAE: I mean I wants to be a drum majorette! *(marching and twirling an invisible baton)*

MAMA: *(laughing)* Well, now you jest oughta do dat, Ida Mae. Ain't nobody kin turn a stick like you do! You is nine years old – but you got mo' sense den folkses ten time ol'er den you is. Yet dere be thangs in dis world you don't know nothing 'bout.

IDA MAE: *(hopping on one foot, she tosses the imaginary baton in the air and catches it)* Thangs like what, Mama?

MAMA: *(sadly)* Thangs dat mama hens gots to do to feed her chicks. I knows dat you is 'shame o' me.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): I never told Mama how my schoolmates low-rated our family. Their insults escalated into the dozens. They'd sing songs they made up to tease me as well.

CHILD: *(sing-song voice)* Mr. So-and-So came a-knockin' on Aint Baby's door, and when his wife finds out, man, will she be sore!

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): They'd accompany the song with nasty gestures to illustrate what went on in the other side of our row house and out back in the wood house.

MAMA: I'm gwine git me my dream, Ida Mae! You gwine see. I be marchin' down yon'er to git my permit to practice!

IDA MAE: You gonna be Somebody!

TRANSITION

The Delta town of Greenwood, Mississippi may have well been the most southern place on the earth and in the 1960's still deeply segregated. The dream of equality, of bettering yourself in a white world was still very much a dream; but for Ida Mae a dream worth fighting for . . .

(echoing in a solemn voice) A story, a story. Another story is coming. Stop talking and listen. Let it go, let it come – African Griot's Preamble

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): **(Pg 210-212)** The people I was working with were interested in one thing and one thing only: freedom.

IDA MAE: *(to Mama, excited)* I be signing' up de folkses to go to de courthouse to vote

MAMA: *(angrily)* Vote! Vote! You be messin' 'round wit' dem Riders who ain't got no sense. You best lissen t'me, gal. Don'cha git in wit' dem fools. All dey gwine do is git a lotta folkses kilt. Stirrin' up trouble twix de white an' us coloreds. Makin' us 'fraid for our life wit' dey talk 'bout reddishin' t' vote and bein' good as de white folkses. Lawdy, Lawd *(looks to the sky)* us'n poor ol' colored folkses needs you now!

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): **(Pg 254)** *(proudly)* In 1963 I was arrested 13 times. My rap sheet included "disturbing the peace," "inciting a riot," "unlawful assembly," and "parading without a permit."

(Pg 290-292) We began 1964 with integration and equality as our goal, led by such big-spirited souls as Bob Moses and Martin Luther King, Jr. The Nobel Peace Prize Dr. King received was hailed as a victory for our cause, but to me it seemed more like a funeral wreath. But by then, Greenwood was no longer a hotbed of Civil Rights activity. On the whole, nobody wanted to stir up white people's anger, so a quiet pall hung over Greenwood. Even the Klan had been strangely quiet [until one morning . . .]

MAMA: *(whispering)* Ida Mae! Ida Mae! Wake up gal an' lissen!

IDA MAE: *(heart pounding)* What is it, Mama? What's wrong?

MAMA: Dem dogs, Lissen how they be barkin'.

IDA MAE: Aww Mama, they just treed a cat.

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MAMA: Gal, I knows how dogs sound when dey tree de cat. Sound t'me like dey gots a crook in de th'oat! C'mon now-git up an' see—An' don't turn dat light on, neither!

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): I stood with the back door open. I doubted whether anyone would want to break into our house; we didn't have anything worth stealing. Still, all the neighborhood dogs were barking. seemed wrong, exactly, but then again, things didn't seem quite right.

IDA MAE: *(crossing arms for warmth)* Just Frisgo and a whole buncha dogs, Mama.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): I chained Frisgo to the wood house and came back in. The sun was almost up, so I filled the tin tub to bathe. I had a big day ahead. A squad of us local Civil Rights workers had assigned ourselves the task of integrating the lunch counter at the white hotel. I would take my seat in the plush "white only" hotel and politely ask for my cup of coffee. I dressed – overalls starched and ironed – clothes I could afford to get beat-up and arrested in.

MAMA: Gal, I don't know why y'all gots t' drank coffee wit' de white folkses who don't want y'all round. Runnin' down yon'er t' cause trouble--

IDA MAE: Mama.

MAMA: Never mind.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): Later, I would spend many sleepless nights trying to recall exactly what happened next. I remember . . . **(Pg 294-295)** I heard the explosion and saw the hot, black smoke turn February into summer, day into night. I heard a scream, but I couldn't move. I knew that trouble had come for me, but there was nothing I could do.

I saw a ball of fire floating across our yard toward the rose bush. The ball rolled over and turned into *(beat – in horror)* Mama! All Mama's skin and hair had burned off, leaving charred flesh and pink muscle. Our old house was gutted ruin, its frame burning greedily. Frisgo's barbecued body dangling by a blackened iron chain from the charred post of the wood house.

Mama was still alive, but barely.

MAN: Don't touch her!

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): *(holding out her hand in horror)* . . . because her skin came off in your hand. Men loaded Mama into the hearse and I piled in after her. **(Pg 296-297)** As we

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screeched down Main Street for the hospital, I found the only unburned place on Mama's body -- the palm of her hand -- and held it gently. There was nothing else I could do.

The next time I saw Mama, she was in the colored wing, bandaged from head to toe.

JEAN: I knowed you was gonna git somebody kilt – messin' wit' dese white folkses!

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): I had broken an important rule of the [Civil Rights] Movement: never take on the power structure without knowing that reinforcements were available. I took a chair on one side of the bed -- a different kind of sit-in. I found the unburned pink palm again and held it. For more than a week, Mama just lay there, wheezing through her scorched throat. A steady stream of friends and relatives came by to pay their respects – one by one they refused to look into my eyes. While I was out in the hall after one of these visits . . .

WHITE NURSE 1: I can't stand the smell of that colored girl!

WHITE NURSE 2: Shhhh! She can't help it. Besides, she won't last much longer.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): When I went back in, Mama's eyes were open for the first time since the fire.

IDA MAE: **(Pg 298-299)** You want water, Mama?

MAMA: *(painfully)* Tote me t'vote, gal.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): *(crying)* I couldn't hug her, so I just clutched the edge of the bed till my knuckles turned white. A few days later, she died. I stood by her bed and it was just me and Mama alone as it had been for so much of my life. Her wide old face was placid -- like it was all finished -- satisfied with what it had done in life and glad to be free of it. I traced Mama's lips with my finger and told her . . .

IDA MAE: I'm gonna be Somebody. You rest now. I swear 'fore God, Mama -- I'm gonna be somebody. *(kisses her)*

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): I'm going to tell you something that you may not believe. After I made my promise, I swear that Mama said, clear as day:

MAMA: Gwine see - thank de Lawd.

NARRATOR (Adult Ida Mae): She had nothing more to say. I suppose I should've been scared or spooked, but all I was was happy. Funny thing is, I continued to hear her voice every now and

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again after that. Sometimes it made me cry, but it never made me sad. I have heard it off and on for years. *(beat)*

(Pg 304-305) After Mama's death, I had a hard time rationalizing the gains we had made as having been worth all they'd cost us. True, there was talk about black children going to the local white schools, but I had heard that kind of talk a decade ago. Dr. Kind led the march from Selma to Montgomery – the last great battle in the voter registration wars. But even that was overshadowed by the 6-day riot in Watts, the black ghetto in Los Angeles – a sign of black people's social and economic frustration. And Malcom X assassinated in New York.

I began to see that a child does not need to dwell in her mother's house forever to be a loyal daughter or stay in her birthplace to remember where she's from. I left Greenwood for good. Like so many others before me, I headed north to find a life that, simply by being "normal," would be better than the one I had left behind.

(Pg 313) Since I've let mama take her ease among the stars, these are thoughts that crowd into my mind most often:

- If you're so far down and out, you feel you can't get back up, I assure you from the bottom of my soul, the journey home is shorter than you think.
- If your mama is still living, give her a great big hug and kiss from me, and always remember where you came from.
- If you happen to be a white man or woman . . . I made it. Those black boys and girls you see around you can make it too. You may give them something had to push against or you may give them a helping hand – that's up to you. But the helping hand feels a lot better.
- Finally make a promise right now that you will never, ***ever*** give up your dreams. If you've been a ho', be a doctor too. If you've hurt a man, be a healer. The world began when you were born. It will be whatever you make it.

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(Pg 308) Twenty years after I'd left the Delta, I marched down the University of Minnesota mall -- the only black face among all the doctoral candidates. **(Pg 311)** I had come a long way from the Mississippi Delta. Somwhere in the midst of all the hollering, I heard my Mama's voice.

MAMA: **(Pg 212)** Lawdy, Lawd *(looks to the sky)* **(Pg 49)** You gots ta have a dream, 'f'n you gwine be somebody.

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